

tomers booking delivery slots in advance until a year ago, has now made quick commerce the default mode on its app. Q-commerce or q-comm brought in 5% of BigBasket's revenues a year ago—that number is a whopping 80% now. It is a competitive landscape dotted by Blinkit, Swiggy Instamart, Zepto, Flipkart Minutes, Amazon Now, and JioMart.

The ambition is clearly there. "We have about 800-plus dark stores. We are opening 40-50 dark stores per month," says Seshu Kumar Tirumala, BigBasket's Chief Buying and Merchandising Officer. "We should cross 920 dark stores by March."

There are 6,563 dark stores across India, making them a veritable competition to mom-and-pop stores and modern trade. While q-comm brings in the volumes, profits are quite another story. Two of the largest players—Swiggy Instamart and Eter-nal's Blinkit—flagged concerns around competi-tive intensity in their earnings for the third quar-ter of FY26. "If competition moderates in the near term, we will want to aim for 3,500-4,000 stores by March 2027," says Albinder Singh Dhindsa, Group CEO, Eternal. "In a rational market, there should be headroom for us to add a significantly higher number of stores in the near future."

Blinkit leads the dark store count with 2,027 fulfilment centres at the end of December 2025. Swiggy's Instamart had 1,136 dark stores across 131 cities at the end of the third quarter of this fiscal, each serving an average of 1,034 orders daily. In all, the network has gone up from 1.95 million square feet in Q2FY25 to 4.79 million square feet at the end of Q3FY26.

Over time, the average size of the dark store has also increased. For Instamart, it has moved from 3,475 square feet to 4,217 square feet. The

THE BIG GUYS

• Dark stores enable more SKUs

RETAIL FORMATS	SKUs
► Q-commerce	10,000
► Supermarkets	3,500
► Kirana	500-1,500
► Hypermarket	10,000

NOTE SKU IS STOCK KEEPING UNIT **SOURCE** KEARNEY

WHAT THE LAW SAYS



ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA

► **IN CONVERSATIONS WITH** India's gig workers, a common refrain emerges: while ser-vices platforms scale, where do they stand in this story?

For years, gig work was not clearly defined. There was no insurance cover or a safety net if demand dipped, an account was deactivated, or an accident occurred. De-spite powering some of India's fastest-growing businesses, gig and platform workers re-mained outside the for-mal labour framework, classified as informal workers with little statutory protection.

That began to change with the Code on Social Security (SS), 2020, which formally recognised gig and platform workers for the first time. The SS Code now requires ag-gregators to contribute 1-2% of annual turn-over to a social security fund, alongside gov-ernment and corporate social responsibility (CSR) support, shifting welfare risks away from workers alone.

While implementa-tion is being worked out, it is clear that the government has cre-ated the foundation for extending social security protections to a rapidly growing seg-ment of workers.

Shivaarti Bajaj,

Co-founding Manag-ing Partner, RSD Bajaj Global Law Firm, says that the SS Code establishes an impor-tant and progressive framework under which platforms may be required to con-tribute toward worker welfare. It empowers governments to design targeted schemes cov-ering health insurance, accident protection, maternity benefits, and old-age support. While some aspects await full operational rollout through notifications, the Code signals that platform-based work will be accompanied by structured social protection, balancing innovation with worker welfare.

"The key issue for platforms is adapting early to the evolving regulatory environ-ment," Bajaj says.

But does the Code allow gig workers to form a union? Ac-cording to Preetha Soman – Partner, JSA Advocates & Solicitors, says the specific protections and mechanisms af-forded by laws govern-ing industrial relations designed for 'workers' in a conventional em-ployment scenario, do not directly extend to them, leaving their col-lective action efforts in a legally precarious position.